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Sonora officials reviewing new law prolonging California's relaxed outdoor dining rules

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Relaxed rules on outdoor dining have been one aspect of California's COVID-19 response that many have actually come to enjoy, and legislation recently signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom will allow that to continue until July 1, 2026.

Several restaurants in the City of Sonora have taken advantage of the flexibility and established outdoor dining areas that remain in place and well utilized even after Newsom ended his pandemic-related state of emergency in March.

The legislation that will allow the eased regulations on outdoor dining to continue, Assembly Bill 1217, was authored by Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, who celebrated Newsom's signing of the law last week in a news release.

"Neighborhood restaurants are the backbone of communities across California, but many are still struggling to recover from the pandemic," Gabriel stated in the release. "Outdoor dining has been a critical lifeline that has helped these beloved establishments keep their doors open during these challenging times."

Gabriel stated that the legislation builds upon AB 61, which he also authored in 2021 to provide for regulatory flexibility on a number of key issues that included enabling more outdoor food preparation and service, allowing restaurants to better use their own outdoor spaces to accommodate more patrons, and extending existing orders that allowed for alcohol to be served outside.

During the height of the COVID-19 pandemic, when most restaurants were not allowed to serve customers indoors, the Sonora City Council passed an ordinance that allowed for outdoor dining under the state's relaxed regulatory framework.

The provisions were set to expire in 2024, which left localities waiting to see whether the state Legislature would take action to prolong the benefits.

City Administrator Melissa Eads said she had not reviewed the legislation as of Oct. 13, though she noted that the city has been working on developing a "process that will allow for the continued, equitable use of outdoor public space by our business community."

"The city recognizes the need to support our businesses, valuing their investment and contribution to the vibrancy of our downtown core," she stated in an email.

Eads added the city has also been working with the Blue Zones Project - Tuolumne County to develop conceptual designs for the future outdoor use of Linoberg Street from South Washington to South Stewart streets, which the council voted shut down and turn into a public park-like area about a year before the pandemic began in early 2020.

Of note, Eads said more than 1,200 people took a survey conducted in relation to the Linoberg Street work and put dining and socialization at the top of uses they wished to see for outdoor spaces in the downtown area.

"Staff looks forward to further review of the legislation and to creating a process that protects and promotes the use of our outdoor spaces in order to enhance the economic vitality, culture, and quality of life amenities our residents and tourists desire," Eads stated.

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